

# The Preparatory Course Route

Every university in Spain that sells a Spanish course and openly says it is preparation for a degree — and the five that name a *máster*. Two agents checked 60+ public and private institutions and every agency pathway provider operating in Europe.

## WHY THIS ROUTE IS WORTH A SEPARATE DOCUMENT

Everything before this compared **language courses** and argued that they count as *estudios superiores* because Instrucción SEM 3/2025 says a *presencial* language course at a recognised higher-education institution qualifies. That argument works, but it is **an argument** — you are asking a consular officer to accept an inference.

The *curso preparatorio* route is different. It does not need an inference, because the Tunis consulate's own page already concedes the point in writing.

*Consulado General de España en Túnez, Visados Nacionales — Visado de estudios: “Los estudios superiores... podrán incluir, en su caso, la realización de un **curso preparatorio a dichos estudios**... que **tendrán igualmente la consideración de estudios superiores**.”*

“Higher studies... may include, where applicable, the completion of a **preparatory course for those studies**... which **shall likewise be considered higher studies**.” — This is on the consulate *you* will apply to, not a ministry circular you have to persuade them to read.

So the question this document answers is narrow and practical: **which Spanish universities actually describe their Spanish course, on their own website, as preparation for a degree?** Not an agency's description. Not a brochure from a recruiter. The institution's own published words, in the institution's own domain.

## What the two agents did

- **Public universities** — all the language centres already on your list plus every other public university with an international Spanish programme: Extremadura, Castilla-La Mancha (Toledo *and* Cuenca), Burgos, Santiago, Carlos III, Alicante, Granada, Málaga, Cádiz, Zaragoza, Salamanca, Complutense, Oviedo, Murcia, Almería, León, Valladolid, Barcelona, Alcalá, Córdoba, La Rioja, Sevilla.
- **Private universities** — ~28 institutions: Nebrija, UCAM, Navarra, Europea, Camilo José Cela, Francisco de Vitoria, the three CEU campuses, Comillas, Pontificia de Salamanca, Deusto, UIC Barcelona, UNEATLÁNTICO, UEMC, San Jorge, Católica de Valencia, Mondragón, IE, Loyola, Ramon Llull, Vic, Villanueva, Isabel I, Fernando Pessoa, Católica de Ávila, Alfonso X, IUNIT.
- **Agency pathway providers** — Kaplan International Pathways, Navitas, INTO, Oxford International, Shorelight, Study Group.

## THE SINGLE MOST USEFUL NEGATIVE

**No UK/US-style pathway provider operates in Spain at all.** Kaplan lists five English-speaking countries. Navitas lists eleven destinations; Spain is not one. INTO, Oxford International, Shorelight and Study Group have no Spanish operation. Anyone selling you a “Spain foundation year” under those brands is selling something that does not exist.

## Five programmes name a máster. Eight more stop at grado.

Out of everything checked, thirteen institutions publish a Spanish course framed as preparation for a degree. Only five of those thirteen say the word *máster*.

### Tier 1 — the course page names a master's degree

| INSTITUTION                       | PROGRAMME                             | TYPE    | PREP PRICE | HOURS     | JAN 2027?    |
|-----------------------------------|---------------------------------------|---------|------------|-----------|--------------|
| Extremadura · IELE, Cáceres       | Master's Pathway Program              | Public  | €2,500     | 20 h/wk   | Yes — 11 Jan |
| Castilla-La Mancha · ESTO, Toledo | Curso Anual ELE                       | Public  | not pub.   | 900 h     | Sept only    |
| Autónoma de Madrid                | Puente a la UAM — Master's Foundation | Public  | €7,500     | 14 h/wk   | Sept only    |
| Nebrija · Madrid                  | Bridge Year Program                   | Private | €8,450     | 15 h/wk   | Yes — 8 Jan  |
| UCAM · Murcia                     | Español Programa Preparatorio         | Private | €5,290     | 22.5 h/wk | Jan (B1–B2)  |

**NOBODY GUARANTEES YOU A MASTER'S PLACE. NOBODY.**

The strongest wording found anywhere in Spain is UAM's “*can apply for early **conditional** admission*”, immediately qualified by “*admission to a Master's degree is subject to the university standard requirements*”. Second is Nebrija's “*you can apply for a **double admission** for a combined program of studies*”. UCAM's “*admisión garantizada*” — guaranteed admission — applies only to its **grado** track for school-leavers, not to the master's.

If an agent or an agency tells you a Spanish university guarantees master's entry after a language year, they are inventing it. Ask them to show you the sentence on the university's own domain.

## The other eight stop at a *grado*

Each of these is a real preparatory programme. Each fails for a different reason, and the reasons are worth knowing so you can recognise the same shapes elsewhere.

### Tier 2 — genuine preparatory course, but it points at a *grado*

| INSTITUTION                    | PROGRAMME                                      | TYPE    | PRICE    | WHY IT DOES NOT FIT YOU                                                |
|--------------------------------|------------------------------------------------|---------|----------|------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Burgos</b>                  | Curso intensivo anual: acceso a la universidad | Public  | €3,000   | Grado at UBU only; entry pitched at <i>bachillerato</i>                |
| <b>Santiago</b>                | Curso Preparatorio de estudios universitarios  | Public  | not pub. | Best name, but names no degree at all                                  |
| <b>Carlos III</b>              | International Foundation Program               | Public  | €8,500   | Grado at UC3M; needs <b>B2 already</b> on entry                        |
| <b>Alicante</b>                | Pathway Programmes                             | Public  | €6,890   | Grado via UNED PCE exams; asks for high-school transcripts             |
| <b>Navarra</b>                 | International Foundation Program               | Private | not pub. | 60 ECTS, grado only, no guaranteed admission                           |
| <b>Alfonso X</b>               | Access to Medicine Programme                   | Private | not pub. | Guarantees a place — in Medicine, a grado                              |
| <b>Católica de Ávila</b>       | Curso Universitario Superior... Preparatorio   | Private | not pub. | <b>Chinese-origin students only</b> ; run by an outside company        |
| <b>IUNIT</b> · adscrito a URJC | Español LCA                                    | Private | not pub. | “acceder a estudios universitarios”, no degree link, nothing published |

## Universidad de Extremadura — IELE, Cáceres

The best-packaged master's route in Spain, and the only Tier 1 programme with a published January 2027 intake.

|           |                                                                                                                                   |
|-----------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| PROGRAMME | Master's Pathway Program (Year 1 = Intensive Spanish Program)                                                                     |
| INTAKE    | <b>11 January 2027</b> · also 9 September 2026 · Sept 2027 not yet published                                                      |
| LOAD      | 1 academic year, 20 h/week, Mon–Fri <b>16:00–20:00</b>                                                                            |
| LEVEL     | A1 → B2, ending in the DELE B2 exam                                                                                               |
| PRICE     | <b>€2,500</b> for the year, plus about €30 for books                                                                              |
| MASTER'S  | UEX official prices, DOE nº 138 of 20 July 2026: <b>€22.91–41.13 per ECTS</b> . A 60-ECTS master is therefore <b>€1,375–2,468</b> |
| ENTRY     | "No special requirements are needed to enroll" — no degree required, no <i>homologación</i> mentioned                             |
| REFUND    | Visa refused → refund minus €150. Visa delayed → free postponement to a later intake                                              |

*"The Master's Pathway Program is designed for international students who wish to pursue a Master's degree at a university in Spain but need to strengthen their Spanish language skills... Upon successfully achieving DELE B2 level in Spanish, **eligible students can progress to a wide range of Master's programs offered by Spanish universities.**"*

IELE's own page. Note the word *eligible* — it is doing all the work. This is preparation, not admission.

### WHAT IELE GIVES YOU THAT NOBODY ELSE DOES

A published two-year table: **Year 1** language, €2,500, 20 h/wk, "Spain Study Visa / Student Residence Permit", work rights up to 30 h/wk → **Year 2** master's, €860–5,000, 10–16 h/wk, "Student Permit Extension". It is the only institution in Spain that lays the whole immigration path out on one page, and the numbers on it check out against the official regional decree.

Documents it issues: Offer Letter on request before you pay, then a Letter of Admission signed by the IELE Director, an invoice, an enrolment letter and the study programme. The brochure says outright: *"Intensive Spanish Language Course is Study Visa application ready."*

### THE WEAKNESS — AND IT IS A REAL ONE

IELE **never uses the regulation's Spanish words**. Not *curso preparatorio*. Not *estudios superiores*. Its strongest phrase is an English marketing heading, "Gateway to Higher Education". A Spanish consular officer reading the file sees an English-language "pathway" product, not a document written in the vocabulary of Art. 52.1.a).

Admissions to the onward master's also route through **Study in Spain Guide**, a private partner — not a university office.

This is fixable and worth fixing: ask IELE, in writing, to certify the year as a *curso preparatorio*. The exact question is on the last page.

## Universidad de Castilla-La Mancha — ESTO, Toledo

The best-worded programme in Spain in the language the regulation is written in — and the one that publishes the least.

|           |                                                                                                                                             |
|-----------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| PROGRAMME | Curso Anual — Español Lengua Extranjera (ELE)                                                                                               |
| LOAD      | 10 months, <b>900 hours</b> , 20 h/week, 9:00–14:00, two semesters (Sept–Jan, Feb–July)                                                     |
| CONTENT   | Gramática 4h · oral 4h · escrita 4h · tutoría 2h, plus options: cultura, SIELE prep, literatura, a 200 h “curso de competencias” April–June |
| LEVEL     | A1–A2 or B1–B2 entry, reaching B2                                                                                                           |
| PRICE     | <b>NOT PUBLISHED</b> – anywhere on the site                                                                                                 |
| DATES     | <b>NOT PUBLISHED</b> – the page still shows the 2023–24 cycle                                                                               |
| ENTRY     | International student over 18. No degree requirement, no <i>homologación</i>                                                                |
| CONTACT   | espanol@uclm.es · +34 926 29 54 02                                                                                                          |

*“Curso recomendado para estudiantes internacionales que necesitan adquirir nivel de español **antes de acceder a estudios de grado o máster en el sistema universitario español.**”*

*“...podrán alcanzar un nivel B2 a lo largo del año que le permita **acceder a estudios superiores de la universidad española.**”*

*“**Possibilidad de ingreso en estudios de grado/máster en la universidad española.**”*

“Course recommended for international students who need to acquire a level of Spanish **before accessing bachelor's or master's studies in the Spanish university system.**” · “...may reach a B2 level over the year allowing them to **access higher studies at the Spanish university.**” · “**Possibility of entry into bachelor's/master's studies at the Spanish university.**”

### WHY THOSE THREE SENTENCES MATTER MORE THAN THEY LOOK

This is the **only page found on any Spanish university website** that pairs the word *máster* with the phrase *estudios superiores* for a Spanish-language course. The consulate's own text says a preparatory course for *estudios superiores* counts as *estudios superiores*. UCLM has written the matching half of that sentence for you, in Spanish, on a public university domain.

It also bundles admissions help: “*Apoyo y orientación en Preinscripción en Grado / Postgrado*” — cut-off lists, managing the pre-registration across **different university districts**, checking admission lists. And NIE processing: “*Apoyo en las tramitaciones con extranjería y policía — Tramitación del NIE.*” That last item is worth real money to you, because the NIE is the bottleneck for working.

### THE VISA DEADLINE IS BUILT INTO THEIR ENROLMENT CALENDAR

“*Hasta el 15 junio (3 meses antes), para los alumnos que requieren documentación para solicitud de visado.*” — “Until 15 June (3 months before), for students who require documentation for a visa application.” And they sell an insurance policy that “*cubre todos los requerimientos exigidos para la obtención del visado*” — “covers all the requirements demanded for obtaining the visa.”

But the course starts in **September**. There is no January entry. For a January 2027 departure this programme is a September 2027 option, not a January one.

### YOU CANNOT PLAN ON THIS YET

No price. No current dates. A page last refreshed for 2023–24. Before this can be compared with Cáceres you have to email [espanol@uclm.es](mailto:espanol@uclm.es) and get the 2027–28 calendar and fee in writing.

## Universidad Autónoma de Madrid — Puente a la UAM

Public, and the only programme in Spain that offers a conditional master's offer before you arrive. It is also three times the price of Cáceres.

|           |                                                                                                                                                                                                   |
|-----------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| PROGRAMME | Puente a la UAM — Master's Degree Foundation Program                                                                                                                                              |
| DATES     | 7 September 2026 → 14 May 2027. September 2027 not yet published                                                                                                                                  |
| LOAD      | Full academic year, <b>14 h/week</b> intensive Spanish plus academic preparation                                                                                                                  |
| LEVEL     | Entry A2–C1; exit <b>B2/C1, recognised by UAM's own graduate school</b> ; SIELE exam included                                                                                                     |
| PRICE     | <b>€7,500</b> (the bachelor's track is €8,000). 10% refunded as a scholarship for strong first-semester grades                                                                                    |
| MASTER'S  | Public per-credit prices under the Comunidad de Madrid decree — and Madrid is the <b>most expensive region in Spain</b> for non-EU master's fees                                                  |
| ENTRY     | Passport, CV, <b>bachelor's degree officially translated and apostilled</b> , transcript, and a grade-equivalence declaration via <a href="https://notasmedias.aneca.es">notasmedias.aneca.es</a> |

*“Students admitted into the Puente a la UAM Program **can apply for early conditional admission in a Master's degree at UAM.**” — followed immediately by — “While participation in the Puente Program helps students prepare for university studies, **admission to a Master's degree is subject to the university standard requirements.**”*

UAM's own page. This is the strongest onward-admission wording anywhere in Spain, and it is still explicitly conditional.

### THE BEST VISA PAPERWORK OF ANY PROGRAMME FOUND

UAM tells you to “request your student visa appointment at the Spanish consulate closest to you” after receiving the offer, and publishes a refund clause that names visa refusal directly: fees are refunded “if the applicant's student visa is denied by the competent consular authority, in which case a copy of the official denial notice must be submitted.” It also flags the two-year post-study job-search authorisation. No other institution publishes this much.

### TWO REASONS THIS IS PROBABLY NOT YOUR PROGRAMME

**The money.** €7,500 for the language year against €2,500 at Cáceres. On a €8,000 budget the Madrid year consumes almost everything before the master's fee — and Madrid's non-EU master's fees are the highest in the country, where Extremadura's are among the lowest.

**The apostille.** UAM is the only Tier 1 programme that demands your Tunisian degree translated and apostilled up front, plus an ANECA grade-equivalence declaration. That is weeks of work in Tunis and it must be finished before you apply, not after.

**And 14 h/week** is the lowest teaching load in Tier 1 — fine legally, since there is no hours rule, but it is the thinnest file to put in front of a consulate.

## Universidad Nebrija — Bridge Year Program, Madrid

Private. Expensive. But it has a January intake, 60 ECTS on the certificate, and it issues exactly the letter a consulate wants.

|             |                                                                                                                                     |
|-------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| PROGRAMME   | Bridge Year Program — marketed as the “Spanish Diploma”, run by the Centro de Estudios Hispánicos                                   |
| LOAD        | 32 weeks, 12 courses of 45 h, <b>60 ECTS</b> ; the fees page states <b>15 h/week</b> . Morning 08:00–14:00 or afternoon 14:00–20:00 |
| DATES       | Año Académico 14/09/2026 → 20/05/2027 · <b>January preparatory 08/01/2027</b> · spring 05/02/2027 → 20/05/2027                      |
| LEVEL       | A2 through C2, DELE preparation included                                                                                            |
| PRICE       | <b>€8,450</b> for the full academic year                                                                                            |
| MASTER'S    | Private fees. Verified example: MA in International Relations, 60 ECTS — <b>€12,260 on campus</b> / €8,550 online                   |
| RECOGNITION | Certificate from the Centro de Estudios Hispánicos. <b>Not a título propio</b> , but it carries ECTS                                |

*“The Spanish Diploma is a **transition-year course designed to guarantee the necessary knowledge of Spanish** to non-Spanish-speaking students, who wish to take on an Undergraduate or **Postgraduate program at a Spanish university.**” · “If you plan to continue your studies in Nebrija University after the Diploma, you can apply for a double admission for a combined program of studies.”*

Nebrija's own page and graduate brochure. The brochure diagram reads: Spanish Diploma Bridge Year + DELE (1 year) → Official Master Degree (1 year). It is a combined *application*, not a guarantee.

### THE DOCUMENT THAT MAKES THIS WORTH LISTING AT ALL

Nebrija's student guide says non-EU students “*deben solicitar el visado especial de estudiante en la Embajada o el Consulado General de España*”, and that on request it issues a **carta de admisión** in which “*se detalla el programa, las horas y las fechas del mismo*” — the admission letter details the programme, **the hours and the dates**. It also issues a separate *carta de participación* for the TIE appointment.

That is precisely the document set a consulate asks for, named in advance. Request it from [info.hispanicos@nebrija.es](mailto:info.hispanicos@nebrija.es).

### THE ARITHMETIC KILLS IT ON YOUR BUDGET

€8,450 language year + €12,260 master's = **€20,710 in tuition alone**, before Madrid rent. Your father's €8,000 does not reach the end of year one. Compare Cáceres: €2,500 + €1,375–2,468 = **under €5,000 for both years**.

Nebrija is the right answer to a different question — if someone else were paying, its January intake and its letter-writing would make it the smoothest file in Spain.

## UCAM — Universidad Católica San Antonio de Murcia

The heaviest teaching load of any programme on this list, and the only one whose name in Spanish is literally *Programa Preparatorio*. It publishes nothing about visas.

|                |                                                                                                                                                |
|----------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| PROGRAMME      | Español Programa Preparatorio, run by the Escuela Superior de Idiomas                                                                          |
| LOAD           | <b>730 hours</b> over the year (the English brochure says 720 — a discrepancy to query). Mon–Fri 09:00–13:30 = <b>22.5 h/week</b>              |
| SHORTER TRACKS | 480 h €4,690 · 636 h · 506 h · 386 h · 256 h · 250 h — down to €2,200                                                                          |
| DATES          | Months only, exact 2027 dates <b>not published</b> . A1–B2 Oct–Jul · A2–B2 Nov–Jul · <b>B1–B2 Jan–Jul, €3,850</b>                              |
| PRICE          | <b>€5,290</b> for the full 730 h year                                                                                                          |
| MASTER'S       | Verified example: MBA presencial, 60 ECTS — €5,650, rising to <b>€6,200 for non-EU students</b> , plus €235 pre-enrolment and €59.12 insurance |
| LEVEL          | A1 → B2, one CEFR level per course, DELE preparation, <i>certificado de aprovechamiento</i>                                                    |

**“Acceso directo a los títulos oficiales en español” · “Acceso al título oficial de Grado o Máster” · “Al finalizar el programa, los estudiantes *podrán acceder a los programas oficiales de Grado o Máster* impartidos en español.”**

**“Direct access to the official degrees in Spanish” · “Access to the official Bachelor's or Master's Degree” · “On finishing the programme, students **will be able to access the official Bachelor's or Master's programmes** taught in Spanish.”** UCAM's student profile also names your exact situation: students “who have completed their Bachelor's degree and wish to undertake a language course prior to the start of their Master's degree”.

### READ THE GUARANTEE CAREFULLY — IT IS NOT FOR YOU

UCAM does use the words *admisión garantizada*, but only here: “*Diseñado para graduados de Educación Secundaria que desean acceder a un programa de **Grado con admisión garantizada**.*” — “Designed for secondary-education graduates who wish to access a **Bachelor's programme with guaranteed admission**.” For a master's the wording drops to “access to”. Third-party sites blur this; topuniversities.com even calls the course a “9 months Postgraduate Programme”, which **UCAM itself never says**.

### NOTHING PUBLISHED ABOUT VISAS AT ALL

Neither the programme pages nor the international-admissions page mentions a visa, an admission letter, or a refund on refusal — only a contact address. Against UBU, UAM and IELE, which publish full visa statements, that is a meaningful gap: you would be relying entirely on email correspondence.

22.5 h/week is the strongest hours figure on this list, and the January B1–B2 track at €3,850 is real. But you cannot see the dates, and you cannot see the visa policy.



## Eight preparatory courses that are not built for you

These are genuine preparatory programmes. They are listed so you can stop considering them — and so you can see exactly why each one fails.

### Burgos — the strongest promise, aimed at the wrong degree

“...alcancen el nivel B2, lo cual les permitirá poder continuar con los estudios de Grado en la Universidad de Burgos. Al finalizar el curso obtendrán un certificado de español que les permitirá acceder a la UBU.” · Requisito: “**Haber finalizado los estudios de bachillerato o una titulación equivalente.**”

“...reach B2 level, which will allow them to continue with Bachelor's studies at the University of Burgos. On finishing the course they will obtain a Spanish certificate that will allow them to access UBU.” · Requirement: “**Having finished secondary studies or an equivalent qualification.**”

€3,000, 620 hours, 19 Aug 2026 → 24 Jun 2027, €400 retained if you cancel. It also has the clearest visa statement in Spain — “*cumple los requisitos establecidos para la solicitud del visado por estudios de Lengua Española*”, “meets the requirements established for a Spanish-language study visa application”. But note what UBU calls it: a **language** visa, not *estudios superiores*. *Máster* appears nowhere on the page. The 2027–28 edition is not yet published; the page is marked *Cerrada*.

### Santiago — the perfect name, attached to nothing

“Otoño — **Curso Preparatorio de estudios universitarios**” is the closest lexical match in Spain to the regulation's own phrase. 16 weeks, 09:15–14:00 plus two afternoon hours in Module 1, 100% attendance compulsory, diploma with ECTS credits, insurance and accommodation included. Its content is genuinely academic: “*Conocer las particularidades del sistema universitario español*” — “To know the particularities of the Spanish university system.” But the page names **no degree, no master's, and no admission route**, and publishes **no price and no 2027 dates**. Visas appear only in the cancellation policy (€100 retained on a documented refusal).

### The rest, briefly

- **Carlos III** — International Foundation Program, 60 ECTS, €8,500, grado at UC3M only, and it requires **B2 already certified on entry**. It is not a beginner's course, so it cannot be your first year.
- **Alicante** — €6,890, 8 months, aimed at the UNED *PCE* exams. Required documents are high-school transcripts and diploma. This is an undergraduate admissions route; a Tunisian graduate has no use for it.
- **Navarra** — International Foundation Program, 60 ECTS, price on request, grado only, up to 15% credit recognition, no guaranteed admission. Its ILCE semester Spanish course is priced clearly (€118/ECTS) but is aimed at reaching B2 for a grado.
- **Alfonso X** — the only guaranteed onward place found in Spain: “*If you successfully complete this course **we guarantee you access to the Degree in Medicine***”. A grado in Medicine. Not relevant, but worth knowing such wording exists, so you can recognise how far short everything else falls.
- **Católica de Ávila** — 10 months to B1, delivered by an outside company (IDEALAR) as a UCAV *título propio*. Restricted to **students of Chinese origin**. Price, hours and dates unpublished; the provider's own page currently 404s.
- **IUNIT** (private centre *adscrito* to URJC, Madrid) — “Español LCA”, explicitly tagged a *título propio*, promising to “*cumplir los requisitos lingüísticos necesarios para acceder a estudios universitarios en España*”. Duration, hours, price and dates all unpublished. Interesting on paper because of the *título propio* label; unusable until it publishes something.

## Long courses that qualify for a visa but never say “preparatory”

These are the courses you were already comparing. They are not worse — several are cheaper and better documented. They just make you rely on the Instrucción argument instead of the consulate's own sentence.

| UNIVERSITY           | COURSE                                                   | HOURS           | DATES             | PRICE    | FRAMING                                                  |
|----------------------|----------------------------------------------------------|-----------------|-------------------|----------|----------------------------------------------------------|
| Barcelona · UB       | Programa de español a tiempo completo <b>para visado</b> | 580 h / 76 ECTS | 09/09/26–29/04/27 | €6,444   | Built for the visa — zero degree wording                 |
| Alcalá · Alcalingua  | Lengua y Cultura, anual                                  | 600 h / 60 ECTS | 01/10/26–31/05/27 | €5,310   | Insurance noted for visas; no degree link                |
| Córdoba · UCOIdiomas | Curso anual de lengua y cultura                          | 600 h / 30 wks  | 14/09/26–26/05/27 | €5,088   | Beginners welcome; no visa or degree framing             |
| La Rioja             | Curso de español, año completo                           | 585 h           | 29/09–06/06       | €3,695   | No framing; semester €2,595 / 390 h                      |
| Sevilla              | Curso intensivo + inmersión                              | 700 h/year      | not published     | approx.  | Requires university-access level at home                 |
| UCLM · ESPACU Cuenca | Curso Anual de Lengua y Cultura                          | 600 h           | Sept–May          | not pub. | Same university as Toledo — but <b>no</b> degree framing |

### THE CUENCA / TOLEDO SPLIT IS THE MOST INSTRUCTIVE FACT HERE

UCLM runs two annual Spanish programmes. Toledo's page says the course leads to *grado o máster* and *estudios superiores*. Cuenca's page, at the same university, says none of it. Same institution, same legal status, different marketing copy.

That tells you the wording is **a website decision, not a legal category**. Which cuts both ways: it means the Toledo sentence is not magic — but it also means any of these universities could write you the same sentence in a letter if you ask. That is what the questions on the next page are for.

## Checked and negative — no preparatory-to-degree course published

**Public:** Granada (part-time only, 6 h/week) · Málaga · Cádiz (only Aptis/Cambridge exam prep is called “preparatorio”) · Zaragoza · Salamanca · Complutense · Oviedo · Murcia (courses labelled *extracurriculares*) · Almería · León (and note: ULE requires certified **C1** for master's entry) · Valladolid.

**Private:** Europea · Camilo José Cela · Francisco de Vitoria · CEU San Pablo, Cardenal Herrera and Abat Oliba · Comillas · Pontificia de Salamanca · Deusto · UIC Barcelona · UNEATLÁNTICO · UEMC · San Jorge · Católica de Valencia · Mondragón · IE · Loyola · Ramon Llull · Vic · Villanueva · Isabel I · Fernando Pessoa Canarias.

**Searched, nothing surfaced — treat as “no evidence”, not as proven absent:** València, Autònoma de Barcelona, Cantabria, Pública de Navarra, Vigo, A Coruña, La Laguna, Jaén, Huelva.

### WHERE THE EXAGGERATION LIVES

Third-party sites consistently overstate what the universities say. [studying-in-spain.com](#) and [gogoespana.com](#) present Nebrija's Bridge Year and Navarra's IFP as if onward admission were guaranteed; neither university says so. [educations.com](#) lists a "Spanish Preparatory Program" category that mixes universities with private language schools and brokers.

There is also a whole industry of Instituto-Cervantes-accredited private schools selling "Programa Pathway" packages — Cervantes Escuela Internacional, Proyecto Español, CLIC, Linguaschools, AIL Madrid, inhispania, Vamos Madrid and others. They run 32–44 weeks and do issue visa paperwork, but they are **language schools, not universities**, they are built around the undergraduate PCE exams, and under Criterios §9 a Cervantes centre "*no se trata de centros educativos en sentido estricto*" — "these are not educational centres in the strict sense". They put you on Route 2, not Route 1.

It does not change your answer. It hardens it.

Cáceres is still first — and now for a second, independent reason

Before this search, IELE Cáceres won on arithmetic: €2,500 for the year, an 11 January 2027 intake, 20 h/week, cheapest cost of living in Spain at about €535/month, and Extremadura master's fees of €22.91–41.13 per ECTS against Madrid's. Both years for under €5,000 in tuition.

It now also wins on **framing**. Of the five programmes in Spain that name a master's, it is the only one that is simultaneously cheap, has a January start, and publishes a complete visa document workflow with a refund on refusal. UCLM Toledo has better Spanish wording but no price and no dates. UAM has better paperwork at three times the price and no January entry. Nebrija and UCAM are private and cost more than your whole budget.

| DECIDING FACTOR         | CÁCERES      | TOLEDO          | UAM          | NEBRIJA    | UCAM            |
|-------------------------|--------------|-----------------|--------------|------------|-----------------|
| Names a máster          | Yes          | Yes, in Spanish | Yes          | Yes        | Yes             |
| January 2027 start      | Yes, 11 Jan  | No              | No           | Yes, 8 Jan | Jan, B1–B2 only |
| Language year           | €2,500       | not pub.        | €7,500       | €8,450     | €5,290          |
| Master's after          | €1,375–2,468 | varies          | Madrid rates | €12,260    | €6,200          |
| Weekly hours            | 20           | 20              | 14           | 15         | 22.5            |
| Visa policy published   | In full      | Partly          | In full      | Yes        | Nothing         |
| Refund if visa refused  | –€150        | not pub.        | Full         | not pub.   | not pub.        |
| Needs apostilled degree | No           | No              | Yes          | No         | No              |

TOLEDO IS THE ONE THING WORTH AN EMAIL BEFORE YOU COMMIT

UCLM is a public university, 20 h/week, 900 hours, and it has already written on its own site the sentence your whole case rests on. If its fee lands anywhere near Cáceres it becomes a genuine second option — and a September 2027 fallback if January slips. If it comes back at €6,000, the question is closed. One email settles it: [espanol@uclm.es](mailto:espanol@uclm.es).

## Three emails, and the exact sentences to ask for

### 1 — To IELE Cáceres, in Spanish

You already have the file. The one thing it does not have is the regulation's own vocabulary. Ask for it directly:

*¿Puede la Universidad certificar por escrito que el curso anual de español constituye un **curso preparatorio** para el acceso a un máster universitario de la UEx, en los términos del artículo 52.1.a) del Real Decreto 1155/2024, y que tiene por tanto **la consideración de estudios superiores**?*

"Can the University certify in writing that the annual Spanish course constitutes a **preparatory course** for access to a university master's degree at UEx, under Article 52.1.a) of Royal Decree 1155/2024, and that it therefore **has the consideration of higher studies**?"

A yes in writing, on university letterhead, alongside their admission letter, is the single strongest document you can put in a Tunis file. A no tells you something useful too: it tells you they know they are selling a language course, and you should read their brochure's promises more sceptically.

### 2 — To UCLM Toledo, in Spanish

*Les escribo desde Túnez. Me interesa el Curso Anual de Español (ELE) del programa ESTO. Les agradecería: (1) el **precio** del curso 2027–2028; (2) las **fechas exactas** de inicio y fin; (3) si existe alguna edición con **inicio en enero**; (4) si expiden **carta de admisión** con el número de horas y las fechas para la solicitud de visado; y (5) qué ocurre con el importe si el visado es denegado.*

"I am writing from Tunisia. I am interested in the Annual Spanish Course (ELE) of the ESTO programme. I would be grateful for: (1) the **price** for 2027–2028; (2) the **exact start and end dates**; (3) whether there is any edition with a **January start**; (4) whether you issue an **admission letter** stating the number of hours and the dates for the visa application; and (5) what happens to the fee if the visa is refused."

### 3 — To UCAM Murcia, in Spanish

Only if you want a third quote. Its 22.5 h/week is the best on the list and the January B1–B2 track is €3,850, but it publishes nothing at all about visas, so ask that first:

*¿Expede la Universidad **carta de admisión** válida para la solicitud de visado de estudios, con indicación de horas y fechas? ¿Cuáles son las **fechas exactas** del programa preparatorio en 2027? ¿Se reembolsa la matrícula en caso de **denegación del visado**?*

"Does the University issue an **admission letter** valid for a study visa application, stating hours and dates? What are the **exact dates** of the preparatory programme in 2027? Is the fee refunded in the event of **visa refusal**?"

#### ONE THING TO KEEP IN PROPORTION

The *curso preparatorio* label is a strengthener, not a requirement. Your route to a Route 1 visa never depended on it: a full-time, in-person Spanish course at a recognised university already qualifies under Instrucción SEM 3/2025, and the nine-university comparison you already have is built on that. What this search adds is a **second, independent argument** that rests on a sentence the Tunis consulate itself published.

Two arguments in one file is better than one. But do not let a missing label push you into a €8,450 programme when a €2,500 one does the same job.

#### THE ORDER TO DO THINGS IN

**This week** — email IELE asking for the 11 January 2027 offer letter *and* the *curso preparatorio* certification. Email UCLM Toledo for its price and dates. **Next** — when both replies land, compare on total two-year cost, not on the language year alone. **Then** — book the Tunis consular appointment as soon as you hold an admission letter, because the appointment queue, not the paperwork, is what usually costs people their start date.